Ruthven and Nanji 2004: 54–55. The position of Ahangaran in the northern reaches of historical Ghur – see Chapter 2 – strongly indicates that some Ghuris were intercepting caravans on the northern route from Herat toward Balkh and beyond. Sultan Mahmud's punitive campaigns there relatively soon after his succession were surely motivated by commercial *and* political factors. Ghaznavid control of Balkh and its surroundings was tenuous in the early years, if we give credence to the *Faḍa'il al-Balkh*, which states that it was only as of the eleventh century that Ghaznavid-appointed *qadi*s were posted in Balkh. This more codified legal structure usually superseded the local, public tribunal system that was customary in many parts of the Persianate world; the process was, expectedly, often not free of conflict. Cf. Azad 2013: 118–119. Not only did the northern Herat–Balkh caravan route comprise an important artery of mercantilism and communication, the zone was vital to Mahmud's control of Khurasan and his increasing independence from his Samanid overlords (Bosworth 1973: 44–46). See also Paul 2018b: 319–320; and de la Vassière 2018: 135–137 for the "gigantic [Kushan] military camp" with a citadel north of Balkh that was likely most used in the Ghaznavid period. The fortress of Jurwas, on the other hand, has not been conclusively located, though its association with the sub-region of Darmashan could indicate southern Ghur, toward Zamindawar (where Kh^{w}abin likely lay). Here again, the above-mentioned caravan routes *via* Tiginabad/Old Qandahar might have been just too tempting to resist for some Ghuris, particularly during the over-wintering months of their seasonal migrations to the south. Cf. Whitehouse 1976: 474ff. for the southern routes *via* Tiginabad/Old Qandahar (see also Chapter 3). It should be remembered that the most direct route of access to Ghur from Ghazna lay *via* Zamindawar – where Mahmud left his three sons while on campaign in Ghur (Baihaqi [trans. Bosworth] 2011, vol. I: 195–196); clearly the Ghaznavid sultans felt compelled to secure *both* the northern and southern routes from the Ghuris' depredations.

7. If the French traveler J. P. Ferrier's reports of the Turkman and Baluchi tribes of Iran and Afghanistan in the mid-nineteenth century can serve as a remote parallel for such activities in the historical past, it is worth considering that the Ghuris also may have been after the *people* traveling with the caravans rather than their goods. The desire for human commodities (according to Ferrier, "man-stealing") may be borne out by the flourishing slave trade centered on historical Ghur, so often mentioned in pre-modern texts. See Ferrier (trans. Jesse) 1976: 83–86; cf. also Khazeni 2012a: 141–143; and Næss 2015 (I am grateful to Dr. Tim Murray for the reference).
8. The phenomenon of mobile groups raiding caravans or even settlements and cities is well known. There is an unfolding scholarly reconsideration of these seemingly parasitic acts, however, as inevitably the impetuses for raiding differed according to specific groups and their circumstances. See further Næss 2015.
9. Cf. Baihaqi (trans. Bosworth) 2011, vol. I: 195, 198–207; and Bosworth 1968a: 35. It is noteworthy that mid-twentieth century Afghan–Pashtun nationalism led the historian 'Atiq Allah Pazhvak to propose a Pashto dialect as the historical language of Ghur (cf. Patel 2017: 151–152).